

**MAURITANIA**

Capital city: Nouakchott
Area: 397,953 sq miles (1,030,700 sq km)
Population: 2,900,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religion: Muslim 100%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Ouguiya
Adult literacy rate: 41%
Life expectancy: 51 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 91 per 1,000 people

NIGER

Capital city: Niamey
Area: 489,188 sq miles (1,267,000 sq km)
Population: 12,000,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Muslim 85%, traditional beliefs 14%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 17%
Life expectancy: 46 years
People per doctor: 25,000
Televisions: 27 per 1,000 people

MAURITANIA

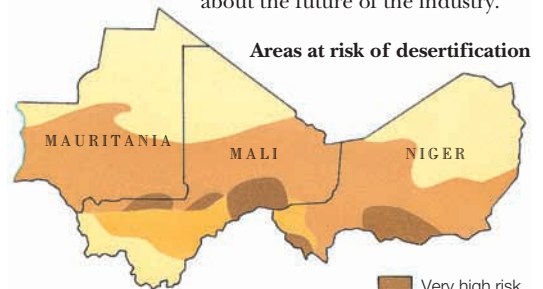
COVERING AN AREA TWICE THE SIZE of Spain, but with a population smaller than Madrid's, Mauritania is one of the emptiest countries in the world. In recent years, many of the people have left the countryside to live and work in the towns, and Nouakchott, the capital, has grown from 20,000 people in 1960 to more than 900,000 today. The country is dominated by the Arab Maures (Moors) from the north, but their political control is resented by the black peoples from the south. Mining is an important industry – Mauritania is rich in phosphates, copper, gold, and other minerals. Drought is a major problem in this region.



Projects like this one for planting trees and grass to hold the soil in place are helping to stop erosion.

**FISHING**

Fleets from all over the world come to fish off the coast of Mauritania, where some of the richest fish stocks in West Africa are found. By law, all fish caught here must be landed and processed in Mauritania before they are exported to overseas markets. However, overfishing of the seas by fleets of trawlers has led to concern about the future of the industry.



This map shows the areas of West Africa that are at risk of turning into desert.

THE SAHEL

Two-thirds of Mauritania is covered by the Sahara, and only the land along the Senegal River is suitable for farming. The semidesert land in between, known as the Sahel, is the grazing land for nomadic farmers. This area suffers from frequent droughts and from soil erosion, made worse by people cutting down the few trees for firewood and by overgrazing cattle. For these reasons – both natural and human – the Sahel is gradually becoming more desertlike.

NIGER

THE VAST STATE OF NIGER is completely surrounded by other countries. Its main link to the sea is the Niger River, the only major river in the country. Most of Niger's 12 million people live in the semi-desert Sahel region, which stretches in a narrow ribbon across the south of the country. North of the Sahel lies the vast and inhospitable Sahara, home to the nomadic Tuareg peoples. Niger has few natural resources aside from uranium, which brought in considerable wealth during the 1980s. Most of the people, however, remain poor, earning their living herding flocks or growing crops in the few fertile parts of the country.

**THE TUAREG**

As a result of frequent droughts in northern Niger, many Tuareg lost all their animals and were forced to give up their nomadic lifestyle. Many moved south to the towns in search of food and work. In reaction to this enforced move, some Tuareg have campaigned for a country of their own.

**FARMING**

Every year, the Niger River floods. As the floodwaters retreat, local farmers quickly plant crops of cereals, rice, vegetables, peanuts, and cotton in the fertile soils left behind. The banks of the Niger also provide pasture for cattle and other livestock reared for meat and milk.

Find out more

NIGER RIVER: 205

SAHEL: 220

SOIL EROSION: 55, 244

TUAREG: 209